AFTER A DISTRESSING EXPERIENCE

You are not alone



Many people feel this way after a distressing experience.

A distressing experience can change how we feel, think, sleep and get along with others. These are common reactions. People react in different ways, and there is no right or wrong way to feel. Support can help, and you do not have to wait to ask for it.



1 Small things that can help

Be with someone you trust
Talk, or simply sit together quietly. You do not have to tell your story.

Rest, eat and drink safe water
Rest when you can. Eat regular meals if you can, and drink safe water.

⚠ **If there is still danger, follow local warnings. Stay away from unsafe places and damaged buildings.**

📖 Want to read more? WHO's illustrated guide Doing What Matters in Times of Stress is available in Nepali.

2 Breathe slowly

1. Breathe in slowly, then breathe out slowly.
2. Notice three things you can see and hear around you.
3. Stop if it makes you feel worse.

Do one small task
Choose one thing you can manage today. Take breaks; you do not have to do everything at once.

Keep daily routines
Regular times for meals, sleep and play help children and adults feel safer.

🔗 **If you take medicine from a doctor, do not stop it without asking a health worker.**

3 Ways of coping that can make things worse

Your feelings are not wrong. But some ways of coping can harm you or the people around you:

- ✕ **Drinking alcohol or using drugs to forget or to sleep**
- ✕ **Staying away from everyone for a long time**
- ✕ **Taking anger out on others, especially children**
- ✕ **Working all day without any rest**

If you notice these in yourself or someone close to you, talk to someone you trust or a health worker.

You may notice


Sadness, worry, fear, anger, or feeling numb


Feeling very tired, aches and pains, headaches. If pain, fever or another body problem worries you, see a health worker.


Trouble falling asleep, or bad dreams


Upsetting memories that come back, or trouble concentrating


Feeling irritable, or wanting to be alone

Children react too

They may cling to you, cry more, or become very quiet. Stay close, explain simply what is happening, and keep familiar routines.

Ask for help early

Feelings getting worse, not going away, or making daily life hard? Talk to a health worker. You do not have to wait.

Get help now

In danger, or thinking of harming yourself? Get help now. Ask a health worker or responder, and ask someone you trust to stay with you.

Help near you: _____ (filled in and checked locally)

_____

_____

Look after yourself. Look after each other.

Support is for everyone, including people with disabilities and older people. Ask for large print or more time.

Sources: WHO, Psychological First Aid: Guide for Field Workers (2011); WHO, Doing What Matters in Times of Stress (2020); IASC, Guidelines on MHPSS in Emergency Settings (2007); WHO/UNHCR, mhGAP Humanitarian Intervention Guide (2015). This material draws on these publications; it was not created by WHO or IASC, which are not responsible for its content.

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